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Government in Zazzau 1800-1950

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(g) The Position of Ex-slaves

Despite clientage, marriage, occupational mobility, fortune, and meritorious religious action, the Hausa system of status distribution remains primarily ascriptive. Moreover, the essential distinction here is between persons whose ancestors were free and those descended from slaves. This distinction is emphasized more heavily than that between the freeborn and the freedmen, since in the fifty years after Lugard's Slavery Proclamation, most freedmen have died. The slave-owners of Zaria, who were Habe as well as Fulani, naturally disapproved Lugard's prohibition of slave-raiding and slave-dealing.¹ At their depositions, Kwassau and Aliyu, the first two emirs under British rule, both had charges of slave-dealing against them. Yet less than 10,000 slaves registered their self-redemption or freedom in the courts of Zaria during the first twenty years of British rule; and the emphasis which Hausa place on free or slave parental status indicates that the freedom which Lugard conferred on children born of slave-parents after 1st April, 1901, has nevertheless been qualified by the fact of their slave parentage.

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Hausa society no longer contains an explicit status of slavery (*bauta*; slave = *bawa*, f. *baiwa*; pl. *bayi*); but Hausa emphasize the status of a person's parents and grandparents. The children of slaves are described as *dimajai* (s. *dimajo* literally, issue of a slave); and the children of *diamjai* are described as *matankara* (literally, grandchildren of slaves). Traditionally, the *dimajo* was inalienable; and under British rule all sale of slaves has been forbidden. The *dimajo* traditionally lived on his master's *rinji*, and shared in certain of the ceremonial exchanges (*biki*) of his owner's family (*iyayen giji*); he laboured on the master's farm and received food and housing in return, his marriage

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was arranged by his master; he was from birth incorporated in the Muhammadan population, and addressed his master as father (*baba*); his master's children, real and classificatory, were his siblings (' *yanuwa*), and some of  254 them were his joking relations. Although not a full member of his master's family, still less an independent legal or political person, the *dimajo* was a member of the master's *kunjiya* (group of dependants), and benefited thereby. Facial marks indicated the slave status of *dimajai* as well as captives. ¹ These facial marks are no longer common; but in many other respects the old *dimajai* relation persists between slave-owners and the issue of their former slaves. The emphasis which Hausa place on parental status as slave or free has the function of maintaining these *dimajai* relations. This emphasis does not contradict Lugard's rule that persons born after 1st April, 1900, are free, but simply ignores it, and it also modifies the effect of self-redemption by slaves.

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See Smith, M. G., 1954, for a comparison of slavery and its abolition in Hausaland and the British West Indies.

For a first-hand account of **Hausa** slavery, see Mary F. Smith, 1954, pp. 40-3, 46 ff., 68 ff., 119-20, 122, 128, etc.

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